

Chapter 84 - Seed

The dramatic upheaval at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate spread across the world overnight. Upon learning that the Divine Venerable had perished to eliminate demons, the four realms¹ (excluding the demon and god clans) were all shocked and grieved. Each realm sent people to Cloud Ascension Mountain to pay their respects, establishing a tomb on the mountain to express gratitude for the Divine Venerable's demon-slaying deed. The mortal realm erected temples overnight to worship the spirit of Divine Venerable Chu Ling in heaven.

Those who unfortunately died in this battle were also recorded by the world, with people sighing in sorrow and regret.

The news that Ning Fuyi, the Young Sect Leader of Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, was actually a naturally born demon and destroyer of worlds also spread like wildfire, terrifying all living beings. Later, when it was learned that Penglai Realm², which had been isolated from the world for a thousand years, had reappeared to protect all living beings and captured this natural-born demon into Penglai, the four realms finally breathed a sigh of relief.

"Penglai has semi-divine bloodline, and after avoiding the world for a thousand years, their strength has greatly increased. With Penglai's protection in the future, we can surely stay away from demonic troubles!" People privately all exclaimed thus.

Penglai took swift action leveraging this reputation, immediately dispatching people to assist the Eastern Wasteland. After repairing the Eastern Wasteland's konghou³, they also helped the six sects subdue demons and eliminate evil. Thus, the four realms that had originally been troubled by demons and monsters quickly returned to peace. Penglai's prestige rose dramatically, having clearly become the leader of the four realms.

Ning Fuyi knew nothing of these matters, nor did she want to know.

She had been motionless in the Canghai Tower⁴ for seven or eight days. Sometimes chaos wrapped around her, sometimes her mind buzzed with noise. Under such torment, these seven or eight days felt like mere moments.

The night-shining pearls that suppressed demons in the tower emitted a faint light, which she stared at blankly, not shedding a single tear.

She couldn't say why - perhaps she was just tired.

What else could she do? Chu Qingqiu was already dead, Rong Jin was gone too, Jiuying's whereabouts were unknown, Xiangsi would never light up again, and Liu Wenzhu had lost her loved one because of the demons - they could never return to the past.

She hated Chu Qingqiu. She had boasted that she would dig up her grave and imprison her corpse, but where was the corpse? She had left nothing behind, not even giving her the chance to act recklessly.

How cruel.

Everything had changed, yet seemingly nothing had changed. When she was reborn, she had sworn to protect her loved ones, yet she still failed to do so, and even caused more people to die.

Perhaps she truly was an ill omen - those who got close to her would never have good endings.

If this truly was her fate, then she accepted it.

People from Penglai came several times, feeding her pills and waving various strange magical artifacts around her body, using the Vajra Demon-Subduing Pestle to force out her demon form. Each and every thing was inhuman torture, but Ning Fuyi seemed to feel nothing at all, just sitting there with her head lowered.

Finally, those people gave up too, locked the tower, and said they would execute her tomorrow.

So be it. After walking the path to the underworld, she wouldn't drink that Meng Po's soup⁵ either. She might as well transform into a flower of the other shore⁶ and end this life.

Ning Fuyi moved backward and leaned against a reef in the tower, closing her eyes.

Time slowly passed. The tightly closed door suddenly showed a crack of light, something slipped in, and the gap closed again.

Someone rustled around fearfully in the sound of waves, finally finding Ning Fuyi by the light of the night-shining pearls. She rushed over with relief, shaking her arm very quietly.

"Sister Ning! Sister Ning!" that person said urgently.

Ning Fuyi was awakened from her drowsiness. She looked up at the visitor - a young girl with large, lively eyes, a small round face, charming and adorable, currently full of worry.

Seeing that although Ning Fuyi opened her eyes, she remained silent, the girl became even more anxious, waving her hands in front of Ning Fuyi: "Sister Ning, don't you remember me? I'm Baili Shiqi⁷!"

Baili Shiqi forcefully tried to pull Ning Fuyi up: "We met in the jianghu⁸ and are already friends. I absolutely don't believe you're a demon! I heard the immortal soldiers say they'll execute you tomorrow, so I secretly snuck in to take you away!"

Her face flushed red as she dragged Ning Fuyi for a long time but couldn't move her an inch, instead becoming breathless from exhaustion.

"Sister Ning! Why won't you leave!" Baili Shiqi was so anxious she was about to cry. She squatted down forcefully: "Penglai is just this strict with immortal rules and never shows mercy, but you can't just believe them! You're not a demon, so you shouldn't suffer this pain!"

"How do you know I'm not a demon?" Ning Fuyi finally spoke, her tone terrifyingly low.

Baili Shiqi shrank back while holding her hand.

However, she immediately gripped Ning Fuyi's arm tightly again, her words charming yet clear: "But I think you're a good person. You saved my life in the village and helped that Cui Shulan who had become a fierce ghost. People of the jianghu value righteousness most. Since I, Baili Shiqi, have decided to trust you, I won't easily change my mind!"

After going through trials, she was still an insufferably naive girl. Ning Fuyi's eyelashes trembled.

Baili Shiqi scratched her ears and cheeks anxiously. She suddenly remembered something, hurriedly pulled out a seven-colored green scale from her sleeve, and pressed it into Ning Fuyi's hand.

Ning Fuyi was stunned. Her mind, which had been occupied by chaos, was like having a block of ice thrown into it, jolting her awake.

"I picked this up outside Penglai's Wangyuan Dungeon⁹. I heard that the divine beast qilin¹⁰ was imprisoned in the dungeon. Lord Wen Yao said the qilin had already fallen into demonhood, and even though it had now recovered its divine beast form, the sins committed while demonized were unforgivable, so they wanted to force her to hand over her beast stone and then suppress her with mystic locks."

Ning Fuyi's eyes widened. Her palm unconsciously dug into the mud, scratching until her five fingers bled.

Jiuying had suffered such torment... while she wanted to die. Ning Fuyi ah Ning Fuyi, how could your heart become less resolute than before after living again?

The dark clouds that had been shrouding her and making her muddled were driven away by the cold ice. Her numb limbs also regained warmth. She suddenly felt something was wrong with her palm and blankly raised her hand.

That stone had somehow become no longer cold, but was radiating warmth.

Grief was no longer suppressed. Ning Fuyi suddenly felt her eyes moisten, teardrops falling from the corners of her eyes, dripping onto the stone.

However, a shocking scene occurred. Through her teary vision, she saw that stone suddenly develop cracks and begin trembling in her palm.

Ning Fuyi hurriedly wiped away her tears. In the gap while she wiped her tears, the side of the stone had completely cracked open, revealing the bright spring-like green within.

"Chu Qingqiu..." For a moment, Ning Fuyi didn't know whether to cry or laugh. The stone trembled too violently and accidentally fell into the mud. Ning Fuyi immediately knelt down, disregarding the dirt as she frantically dug through the soil. Her hands mixed with blood and mud as she finally found the stone in a corner and picked it up with trembling hands.

"It's actually a seed, it's actually a seed." Ning Fuyi couldn't describe her current feelings. She cried and laughed alternately, like a person trapped in the desert who had seen sweet rain, her despairing heart moistened by the sweet rain.

"Shiqi, quickly..." Ning Fuyi reached for Baili Shiqi.

Seeing this woman with cold, stern, beautiful features appearing so seemingly mad, Baili Shiqi watched and cried along with her. She hurriedly searched through her pouch, took out a deep-sea glazed cup to serve as a flower pot, dug up soil from the ground to fill it, and watched Ning Fuyi carefully bury the seed inside.

Ning Fuyi held the glazed cup and bent down, biting her lip as she cried and laughed, tears dripping into the cup. The seed emitted a faint green light in the soil.

Seeing that Ning Fuyi's face no longer showed only withered defeat, Baili Shiqi wiped her tears and smiled: "Sister Ning, these are all your things. I brought them all to you."

She placed some miscellaneous items in front of Ning Fuyi - the now-motionless Xiangsi and a pitch-black thought bead¹¹, then took out another item and handed it to Ning Fuyi.

"I caught this outside Penglai. It was hiding behind the immortal soldiers following you all the way. Though I don't know what this thing is, I thought it must be yours."

Ning Fuyi looked at the sizzling thing and let out a long sigh with a crying tone.

It was the Emei Thorns¹² that had lost their master after the demon's death.

Life really went in circles, playing with her like a monkey.

Ning Fuyi put down her sleeve. Her expression had returned to coldness. She put on the thought bead, hung the dimmed Xiangsi small at her chest, and finally picked up the Emei Thorns.

Just like in her previous life, the Emei Thorns almost instantly recognized her as master, transforming into a black ring that encircled her fingertip, excitedly spinning around.

Pink lightning surged from her fingertips throughout her entire body, awakening the immortal power within her that had been tortured to exhaustion. The immortal power flowed through her body, and she finally regained her strength.

She staggered to her feet, looked steadily at the seed once, placed it in a thought bead, then turned around with a sweep of her sleeve. The green robe covered in blood and mud instantly faded away, replaced by ink-black clothing.

This lifetime had been too beautiful, so beautiful that she had forgotten what kind of person she was supposed to be.

"Shiqi, take me to the dungeon," her cherry lips parted lightly.

She couldn't die. She had to rescue Jiuying, she had to find out the truth, she had to kill all those who harmed her, she had to bring Chu Qingqiu back and watch her cry, watch her regret.

She had to wait soberly for that day.

In Penglai's Wangyuan Dungeon, said to be the most terrifying place in the six realms, even the halls of Yama in the underworld and the demon caves of the demon realm were inferior by several degrees.

Here imprisoned countless of the world's most evil beings. The howls and cries of demons and fiends echoed endlessly, and heavy flames roasted them, punishing these sinners who had gone mad countless times.

In the most remote dungeon, a beautiful woman was bound hand and foot with iron chains, hanging in mid-air, swaying gently with wind from unknown sources. Several fresh scars ran across her usually proud and beautiful face, and she closed her eyes powerlessly.

Her beautiful arms were covered with wounds, and several beast scales had fallen off, emitting blue light at her feet.

Every time the fiends being punished in the distance howled, she trembled accordingly.

"Worthy of being a demon beast, really can endure. Believe it or not, I'll strip off all your scales to make armor!" The immortal general interrogating her held a soul-whipping long whip, throwing it forcefully on the ground. "Hand over your beast stone, promise never to be a demon again, admit your guilt and submit to the law, and we naturally won't interrogate you anymore!"

Jiuying slowly raised her eyes, revealing golden, enchanting pupils. Her eyeballs moved, and she made a spitting gesture with her hands bound in iron chains.

"This old lady is a divine beast."

"You fools with your sanctimonious facade also want to force me to submit? You don't even look at how inferior you are!" She spat out bloody saliva and laughed coldly.

The immortal general flew into a rage upon hearing this and wanted to strike again, but was stopped by another older immortal general beside him.

"You demon beast, don't refuse a toast only to drink a forfeit," that person snorted coldly. "What divine beast - just a spirit pet contracted with a small demon creature."

Jiuying's five fingers gripped the iron chains tightly, glaring fiercely at him.

"Are you still hoping that demon creature will come to save you? You're here charging into battle for her, but she's long since escaped. Why do you need to be so obstinate?" The immortal general stroked the long whip in his hand and sneered.

"What did you say?" For a moment, the determination on Jiuying's face cracked, then she hoarsely cursed again: "I, Qi Jiuying, would never believe your lies!"

"Believe it or not, it's up to you. You think yourself a descendant of the god clan, but you're not a god - you're a beast! You were born to be contracted and domestically raised as a pet. Once you enter this Wangyuan Dungeon, you can never leave. Which person would risk their life to come save a spirit pet?"

"Stop dreaming. In life-and-death situations, who would care about you? They'll only use you to escape themselves. You were trapped in Tongchuan Ghost Eye for ten thousand years - surely you understand this principle by now?" The immortal general laughed mockingly.

Jiuying's hands began to tremble. She gripped the iron chains tightly, but the scene that haunted her heart day and night floated in her mind.

She was stepped on the chest by Chidu and trampled into the bottomless abyss of the Ghost Eye.

She bit her lip and lowered her proud head. Tears turned into balls of flame, still burning with small fires when they hit the ground.

"It won't happen," her voice became much softer. "It won't..."

"Hand over the beast stone, and your suffering will end. You'll never have to be a spirit pet that people can manipulate at will anymore." The immortal general's words were gentle as he slowly approached her, watching the blazing fire in her eyes and her gradually disturbed stance.

"Hand over..."

The immortal general's words suddenly stopped. Ice-blue light silently flew out from the void, piercing his neck and silently bringing him down.

Then, the Emei Thorns that had broken free spun several circles in mid-air, cutting through the four iron chains binding Jiuying. Before Jiuying could react, her body instantly fell.

An ink-colored shadow flashed beneath her. Jiuying landed on the woman's soft back. The woman's warm hand pulled her wrist to help her steady herself, and a familiar clear voice rang out.

"Qi Jiuying, you held on."

"I'm taking you out!"

Footnotes:

1. **Four realms (四界):** The immortal realm, demon realm, human realm, and beast realm - the main divisions of the cultivation world
2. **Penglai Realm (蓬莱境):** A powerful immortal sect that has been in seclusion, based on the mythical Penglai Island
3. **Konghou (箜篌):** An ancient Chinese harp-like musical instrument, here likely a magical artifact
4. **Canghai Tower (沧海塔):** "Vast Sea Tower" - a prison tower where Ning Fuyi is being held
5. **Meng Po's soup (孟婆汤):** In Chinese mythology, the soup that erases memories of past lives when souls are reincarnated
6. **Flower of the other shore (彼岸花):** Also known as spider lily, associated with death and the afterlife in East Asian culture
7. **Baili Shiqi (百里拾七):** "Hundred Li Seventeen" - a young girl who befriended Ning Fuyi
8. **Jianghu (江湖):** The martial arts world or community of wandering fighters and adventurers
9. **Wangyuan Dungeon (妄怨地牢):** "Delusion and Resentment Dungeon" - Penglai's prison for demons and evil beings
10. **Qilin (麒麟):** A mythical Chinese creature, often translated as "Chinese unicorn," considered a divine beast
11. **Thought bead (一念珠):** A magical storage device, literally "one thought bead"
12. **Emei Thorns (峨眉刺):** Weapon that originally belonged to the demon that was killed, now recognizing Ning Fuyi as its master